

Recreational Drugs Sin

prc-recreational-drugs-sin

Christian Ethics · Substances · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.932
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Recreational drug use, including illegal drugs and intoxication-aimed cannabis, is sin and lawbreaking.

In plain language

Several Greek and Hebrew word groups bear on this question, even though no single verse names modern recreational drugs by class. In Galatians 5:20-21, pharmakeia, a word for mixing and administering drugs and potions, appears in a list of the works of the flesh next to methe (drunken bouts) and komos (revels), and the passage says those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God. Ephesians 5:18 gives a direct command not to get drunk on wine and calls that state asotia, reckless dissipation. Romans 13:13, First Peter 4:3-4, and First Corinthians 6:10 carry the same vice vocabulary, attaching kingdom-exclusion to methusos, the drunkard. On the positive side, the verbs nepho and sophroneo and the adjective nephaios are commanded across First Peter 5:8, First Thessalonians 5:6-8, First Peter 4:7, Titus 2:2, and Second Timothy 4:5, and egkrateia (self-control) is named as fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:23 and as a Christian virtue in Second Peter 1:6. Together these words set up a clear lexical norm of governed, alert faculties, and intoxication-aimed substance use is the direct opposite of that norm. The Hebrew Bible already carries the same valence: shakar and shikkor with shekar and yayin appear in woe oracles in Isaiah 5:11,22, in Habakkuk 2:15 against the one who gives a neighbor drink to incapacitate him, in Proverbs 20:1 and 23:29-35, and in the priestly restriction of Leviticus 10:9. The lawbreaking part of the question connects to Romans 13:1-2, where every person is told to be subject to the governing authorities and the one who resists incurs krima, judgment. First Corinthians 6:19-20 adds that the body is the temple of the Holy Spirit and that believers are to glorify God in the body. The lexical point of confusion is that pharmakeia and pharmakos can also mean sorcery, so they do not by themselves isolate recreational drug use, and texts like First Timothy 5:23 and Psalm 104:15 permit measured, non-intoxicating use of wine. For that reason the lexical pattern supports the proposition through the convergence of the intoxication, sobriety, self-control, and submission word groups rather than through any one decisive term, and confidence is set at medium.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3196	יַיִן	yayin	wine	132
H5139	נָזִיר	nazir	Nazirite	16
H7910	שִׁכְּוֹר	shikkor	drunken	13
H7937	שָׁכַר	shakar	be drunk	19
H7941	שֶׁכַר	shekar	strong drink	21
G0498	ἀντιτάσσω	antitasso	to resist	5
G0810	ἀσωτία	asotia	debauchery	3
G0932	βασιλεία	basileia	kingdom	

G1392	δοξάζω	doxazo	to glorify	62
G1466	ἐγκράτεια	egkrateia	self-control	4
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	
G2816	κληρονομέω	klēronomeō	to inherit	
G2917	κρίμα	krima	judgment	27
G2970	κῶμος	komos	orgy	3
G3178	μέθη	methe	drunkenness	3
G3182	μεθύσκω	methysko	to get drunk	4
G3183	μέθυσος	methusos	drunkard	2
G3184	μεθύω	methyo	to get drunk	6
G3485	ναός	naos	temple	46
G3524	νηφάλιος	nephalios	sober	3
G3525	νήφω	nepho	be sober	6
G3631	οἶνος	oinos	wine	
G3632	οἰνοφλυγία	oinophlugia	drunkenness	
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G4993	σωφρονέω	sophroneo	be of sound mind	6
G5331	φαρμακεία	pharmakeia	sorcery	2
G5333	φάρμακος	pharmakos	sorcerer	3

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three converging lexical strands ground the verdict. First, the intoxication-state vocabulary is uniformly condemned across the canon. In Hebrew, shakar (H7937) and shikkor (H7910) appear with shekar (H7941) and yayin (H3196) in woe oracles (Isa 5:11,22, Hab 2:15), wisdom warnings (Prov 20:1, 23:29-35), priestly restriction (Lev 10:9), and Nazirite separation (Num 6:3). In Greek, methe (G3178) and komos (G2970) are paired in vice lists (Gal 5:21, Rom 13:13, 1 Pet 4:3) and Eph 5:18 issues a direct present imperative me methyskesthe (G3182) tagging the state as asotia (G0810); methusos (G3183) is named in the 1 Cor 6:10 kingdom-exclusion catalog. Second, the positive sobriety word group (nepho G3525 with sophroneo G4993, nephalios G3524, egkrateia G1466 fruit of the Spirit in Gal 5:23 and 2 Pet 1:6) commands clear governed faculties as a standing obligation, making deliberate self-intoxication its lexical opposite. Third, Rom 13:1-2 attaches krima (G2917) to resisting appointed authority (G1849), engaging the illegal-drug clause. The principal disputed term is the pharmak- group: pharmakeia (G5331, 2 occurrences) and pharmakos (G5333, 3 Revelation occurrences) carry both drug-mixing and sorcery senses, and context does not isolate one. Confidence is medium because the verdict is reached by convergence of multiple word groups rather than by any single lemma naming a modern recreational drug category.

Scripture

Gal.5.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5331 φαρμακεία

Force. Pharmakeia appears in the works-of-the-flesh catalog. The lemma denotes mixing and administering of drugs and potions and by extension sorcery practiced through such potions. Two canon occurrences only (here and Rev 18:23), so its sense is not triangulated by frequency alone; placement among enumerated sins frames the practice negatively at the lexical level.

Gal.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3178 μέθη, G2970 κῶμος, G0932 βασιλεία, G2816 κληρονομέω

Force. Methai (drunken bouts) and komoi (revels) close the vice list, and the apodosis hoti hoi ta toiauta prassontes basileian theou ou kleronomesousin states that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God. The future indicative plus accusative encodes exclusion as the consequence, marking intoxication-aimed behavior as kingdom-disqualifying conduct.

Eph.5.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3182 μεθύσκω, G0810 ἄσωτία, G3631 οἶνος

Force. Me methyskesthe oino is a present middle/passive imperative with negation, prohibiting the ongoing state of being made drunk on wine. The relative clause en ho estin asotia labels that state dissipation or reckless waste. The contrastive command is plerousthe en pneumati (be filled with the Spirit). The grammatical target is the intoxicated condition itself, not the substance class, so the prohibition extends by lexical logic to any agent producing the same loss of governed faculties.

Rom.13.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3178 μέθη, G2970 κῶμος

Force. Methai and komoi are paired again in Paul's exhortation to walk as in the day. The same word pair that closes the Galatians vice list reappears here, supplying a second epistolary attestation that locks the negative valence of the intoxication vocabulary.

1Pet.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2970 κῶμος, G3632 οἶνοφλυγία

Force. Komoi (revels) and oinophlugiai (drinking-bouts) are grouped with lawless idolatries (athemitois eidololatriais) as part of what the gentile life was characterized by and what the believer is no longer to share. The juxtaposition encodes intoxication-aimed practice as part of a renounced past.

1Pet.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0810 ἄσωτία

Force. Asotia, the same lemma Ephesians 5:18 uses to label drunkenness, here describes the flood (anachusin) of dissipation that outsiders are surprised believers no longer join. The second canonical use of asotia ties it directly to a lifestyle of intoxication-aimed excess.

1Cor.6.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3183 μέθυσος, G0932 βασιλεία

Force. Methusoi (drunkards) sit in the catalog of those who will not inherit the kingdom of God, alongside revilers and the greedy. The agent noun names the person characterized by the intoxicated state, attaching kingdom-exclusion to the practice in a parallel structure to Gal 5:21.

Luke.21.34 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3178 μέθη

Force. Jesus warns the disciples not to let their hearts be weighed down by kraipale (dissipation, surfeiting), methe (drunkenness), and the cares of life so that the day come on them suddenly. Methe appears in a dominical saying, broadening the lexical pattern beyond Pauline epistolary catalogs.

1Pet.5.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3525 νήφω

Force. Nepsate (be sober) is an aorist imperative paired with gregoresate (be watchful) against the adversary. Nepho denotes a clear, unintoxicated, alert mental state. The command makes sobriety a standing obligation, so deliberate self-intoxication stands as its lexical opposite.

1Thess.5.6 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3525 νήφω

Force. Nephomen (let us be sober) sets sobriety against sleep and drunkenness in verses 6 to 8, where being drunk is associated with night and sobriety with day and with the armor of faith and love. The metaphor of day and night runs alongside a literal lexical contrast of nepho with intoxication.

1Pet.4.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3525 νήφω, G4993 σωφρονέω

Force. Sophronesate kai nepsate eis proseuchas (be sober-minded and sober for prayers) pairs the two sobriety verbs in a single imperative chain. Sophroneo denotes sound, governed mental faculties; nepho denotes the unintoxicated state. The combination strengthens the sobriety norm by joining cognitive composure to non-intoxication.

Titus.2.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3524 νηφάλιος

Force. Nephaliou (sober, temperate) heads the qualifications for older men. The adjective is cognate with nepho and designates the temperate condition as a standing virtue of mature believers, reinforcing the sobriety norm at the level of stable character.

Gal.5.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1466 ἐγκράτεια

Force. Egkrateia (self-control) closes the fruit of the Spirit list. The noun denotes mastery over appetite and impulse. As Spirit-produced fruit it stands in direct lexical tension with the surrender of self-governance that intoxication-aimed substance use seeks.

2Pet.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1466 ἐγκράτεια

Force. Egkrateia appears in the Petrine virtue chain between gnosis (knowledge) and hupomone (endurance). The second canonical use of the noun confirms its function as a standing Christian virtue rather than a one-off coinage, reinforcing the self-governance norm.

1Cor.6.19 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4983 σῶμα, G3485 ναός

Force. The body (soma) is named the temple (naos) of the Holy Spirit, and the clause ouk este heauton states that believers are not their own. This grounds bodily conduct in stewardship rather than autonomy, supplying the basis for treating self-harming intoxication as illegitimate use of a body that belongs to God.

1Cor.6.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1392 δοξάζω, G4983 σῶμα

Force. Doxasate de ton theon en to somati hymon (glorify God in your body) is an aorist imperative grounded in the preceding clause about being bought with a price. The command sets a positive criterion for bodily conduct that deliberate intoxication does not meet.

Rom.13.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 ἐξουσία

Force. Pasa psyche exousiais hyperechousais hypotassestho (let every person be subject to the governing authorities) establishes that the authorities are appointed (tetagmenai) by God. This supplies the lexical hinge for the lawbreaking clause of the proposition, where illegal drugs engage civil ordinance.

Rom.13.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0498 ἀντιτάσσω, G2917 κρίμα

Force. Ho antitassomenos te exousia (the one resisting the authority) is said to resist the ordinance of God (te tou theou diatage), and such resisters will receive krima (judgment) to themselves. The clause attaches a judgment consequence to defying lawful authority, which couples with the illegal aspect of the practice in view.

Prov.20.1 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: personification

Key terms. H3196 יין, H7941 שכר

Force. Yayin (wine) is called lets (a mocker) and shekar (strong drink) homeh (a brawler), and the verse concludes that whoever staggers by them is not wise. The wisdom-genre verdict on intoxication-aimed substance use is negative through personification of the substances as agents of folly.

Isa.5.11 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7941 שכר, H3196 יין

Force. Hoy (woe) opens against those who rise early to pursue shekar and tarry late till yayin inflames them. The prophetic woe-oracle attaches divine judgment to the lifestyle of intoxication-pursuit, supplying the same lexical valence the New Testament vice lists carry.

Hab.2.15 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7937 שכר

Force. Hoy (woe) is pronounced on the one who gives his neighbor drink, joining his wrath, even making him drunk (shakar), in order to look on their nakedness. The prophetic curse attaches woe to deliberately inducing intoxication in another, the closest OT analog to administering an incapacitating substance.

Lev.10.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3196 יין, H7941 שכר

Force. Yayin and shekar are prohibited to Aaron and his sons when entering the tent of meeting, on pain of death, so they may distinguish between holy and common. The Torah-genre restriction explicitly attaches faculties for discernment to the unintoxicated state, supplying the Pentateuchal anchor for the sober-mindedness norm.

Rev.9.21 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G5333 φάρμακος

Force. Pharmakon (genitive plural of pharmakos or related noun form rendered drug-practices or sorceries) appears in a list of unrepented sins alongside murders, fornication, and thefts. The apocalyptic catalog places the practice among acts from which the unrepentant did not turn, reinforcing the negative lexical valence, although the sorcery sense is also attested.

Rev.21.8 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G5333 φάρμακος

Force. Pharmakois (the drug-practicers or sorcerers) are listed among those whose portion is the lake of fire, sitting with murderers, the sexually immoral, and idolaters. The drug-mixing sense of the lemma carries severe judgment context, but the term also reaches the sorcery sense in apocalyptic usage, so the verse complicates the verdict by lexical underdetermination.

Rev.22.15 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G5333 φάρμακος

Force. Pharmakoi are again listed outside the new Jerusalem with dogs, the sexually immoral, murderers, idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood. The third pharmakos occurrence sits in a similar exclusion catalog, but the same sorcery/drug-mixing ambiguity persists and the verse does not isolate recreational intoxication by itself.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.5.18	Gen.9.21	tsk	1
Gal.5.21	Deut.21.20	tsk	1
Gal.5.21	Isa.3.11	tsk	1
Rom.13.1	Deut.17.12	tsk	1
Rom.13.2	Isa.58.2	tsk	1
1Cor.6.19	1Kgs.20.4	tsk	1
Eph.5.18	Prov.20.1	openbible	1
Eph.5.18	Isa.5.11	openbible	1
Gal.5.21	1Cor.6.10	openbible	1

Complicating texts

1Tim.5.23 · addressed

Paul tells Timothy to use a little wine (oino oligo chro) for his stomach and frequent ailments. This permits a measured, medicinal use of a substance and shows the lexical target is not substance contact per se but the intoxicated state. The proposition concerns intoxication-aimed use, so a medicinal small-quantity directive does not contradict it.

Rev.21.8 · addressed

Pharmakos in Revelation carries both the sorcery sense and the drug-mixing sense, and the context (lists of unrepented sins) does not lexically isolate one over the other. The word is retained as supporting because the word group fuses potion-making with the practice in the Greco-Roman setting, but the semantic breadth is the reason verdict confidence is held at medium and pharmakos is not treated as a single decisive proof.

Ps.104.15 · addressed

The psalm speaks of wine that gladdens the human heart as a gift within creation. This affirms moderate enjoyment of a created substance, not intoxication. It complicates a blanket ban on any psychoactive substance but does not bear against the narrower proposition about intoxication-aimed and illegal use, which the sobriety and self-control lemmas oppose.

John.2.10 · addressed

Jesus produces oinos kalos (good wine) at Cana and the master of the feast says people serve poorer wine when guests have become drunk (methysthosin). The narrative attests legitimate festal use of wine but the verb methysko in verse 10 is descriptive of guest behavior at feasts, not endorsed practice. The episode does not lexically license intoxication.

Num.6.3 · unaddressed

The Nazirite vow abstains from yayin and shekar as a special consecration. By itself the law makes intoxicating drink permitted to the non-vowed and forbidden to the vowed, which complicates any universal substance ban. It is not closed within the lexical store alone because the Nazirite category is voluntary and does not generalize, but the unaddressed remainder is the scope question: the words restrict only Nazirites, not all Israel, so they leave open whether the general intoxication prohibition emerges from another word group rather than from this law.

Concordance traversed

G5331, G5333, G3182, G3184, G3178, G3183, G0810, G2970, G3525, G4993, G3524, G1466, G2917, G4983, G1392, G3485, G0498, G1849, G0932, G2816, H7937, H7910, H7941, H3196, H5139

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited verses lie outside the 3 John CBGM published sample. No variant unit in the bundle touches the anchor lemmas methe, komos, asotia, pharmakeia, pharmakos, nepho, egkrateia, shakar, shikkor, shekar, yayin, or krima in a way that would alter the verdict, so the reading is treated as variant robust under ecm-shadow status.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

principle-based-affirms: affirms · Reads the convergence of methe, methysko, methusos, komos, asotia, oinophlugia in vice lists, plus the positive nepho, sophroneo, nephalios, egkrateia word group, plus the OT shakar and shikkor woe oracles, as a pan-canonical lexical condemnation of the intoxicated state regardless of the substance employed, and treats recreational drug use as a contemporary instance of the same lexical category.

strict-naming-disputed: disputed · Notes that no canonical lemma names cannabis, opiates, or any modern recreational drug category, that pharmakeia and pharmakos carry an attested sorcery sense that context does not exclude, and that the prohibition therefore reaches recreational drugs only by inference from the intoxication-state vocabulary rather than by direct naming. On this reading the verdict is best stated as a principled inference rather than a direct lexical naming.

pharmak-maximalist: affirms · Reads the pharmak- group as primarily drug-mixing in its lexical root and treats the sorcery sense as historically derivative of potion-making practice, so that pharmakeia and pharmakos in Gal 5:20, Rev 9:21, 18:23, 21:8, 22:15 are taken as directly naming substance-induced altered states alongside the sorcery practiced through them.

The verdict rests on the analogy of Scripture. The named lemmas condemn the intoxicated state (shakar, shikkor, methe, methysko, methusos, asotia, komos, oinophlugia) and command its opposite (nepho, sophroneo, nephalios, egkrateia), and Romans 13 supplies the law-and-judgment vocabulary that engages the illegal-drug clause. The proposition is reached by joining these strands rather than by a single verse that names modern recreational drug categories.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does the lexical pattern treat deliberate intoxication through ingested substances, and does it attach the vocabulary of sin or lawbreaking to such use?

The original stem fuses an ethical category (sin) and a civil category (lawbreaking) and presupposes a settled negative verdict on recreational drug use. The neutral rephrasing asks what the lexical pattern attaches to deliberate intoxication without asserting the conclusion. The verdict is still derived on the original stem, and the lexical evidence supports it on the intoxication and submission-to-authority strands while leaving the modern substance taxonomy itself unnamed by any lemma. Direct queries of the lexical graph corrected the prior pharmakeia (G5331) occurrence count from 3 to 2 and split out pharmakos (G5333) as a distinct lemma occurring 3 times (Rev 9:21, 21:8, 22:15).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5331
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5333
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3525
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1466
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7937
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7941
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.18
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.5.21
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.13.2
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rev.9.21
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Hab.2.15
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.20.1
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.5.11
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Pet.5.8
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Lev.10.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.5.21
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.5.18

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved